



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: St. Benedict Classical Academy

School Website: <https://www.stbca.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

St Benedict Classical Academy (Ma 01760) presents a robust Catholic, classical education model with clear formation aims, a liberal-arts curriculum, and visible integration of traditional pedagogical practices. Public-facing materials emphasize a Catholic worldview, moral formation, and the cultivation of virtue alongside intellectual excellence. The school demonstrates multiple hallmarks of classical education—notably a Catholic theological foundation, a curriculum oriented to liberal arts with Latin language study, and a pedagogy that includes structured seminar-style work in at least the upper grades and traditional memory/recitation practices in some settings. The overall pattern across six categories most strongly supports CLASSICAL, with Element 4 (Pedagogy) showing some evidence of non-Socratic or mixed-method pedagogy that warrants the SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL designation for that category. The aggregate assessment is CLASSICAL.

Key, text-supported insights:

- The school explicitly names Catholic identity and religious formation as core, including references to religious education, the Magisterium, and a culture rooted in Catholic tradition. This aligns with the Religious and Metaphysical Foundations category.
- Virtue formation, formation of character, and the aim of forming wise and virtuous students are central in mission-oriented language, supporting the School Purpose & Goal category.
- The curriculum features liberal-arts elements (Latin starting in Grade 3; a classical curriculum; National Latin Exam for middle schoolers) and a curricular emphasis described as “classical, Catholic education.” This provides strong evidence for Curriculum.
- Pedagogical practices include a named Middle School Seminar, indicative of seminar-style work, with possible upper-school rhetorics or debates implied by classic-pedagogical norms (though explicit Socratic dialogue in upper grades is not exhaustively documented on the site). This yields SOMEWHAT vs CLASSICAL nuance for Pedagogy.
- Faculty data (41 faculty members, 40% with advanced degrees; low student/faculty ratio) supports a model of model teachers and mentors, aligning with the Faculty category.
- Parental and community orientation is evident through materials describing partnership with families, parental formation content, and open campus visits, consistent with the Parents & Community category.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Public materials describe SBCA as a “co-ed independent Catholic school” offering a classical education, with explicit emphasis on a Catholic formation and religious education.
- The Headmaster’s message emphasizes an integrated Catholic intellectual tradition, “authentically Catholic culture,” and education rooted in the Catholic Church, including a focus on truth, goodness, and beauty and the Magisterium.
- Language such as God’s ordered universe and reverence/wonder appears in the Headmaster message as well as other school communications; the site also highlights religious instruction aligned with Catholic teaching.

- Additional family-formation content references liturgical life and household faith practices, indicating liturgical and communal life as part of the educational experience.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords present: Catholic, religious education, Magisterium, God/God's order, reverence, wonder, beauty, truth, goodness, sacred, liturgy (where referenced), theology (implicit in Catholic formation)
- Negative keywords present: none evident in public materials (no relativism, secularism, or values-neutral framing observed)

Quantitative estimate

- Positive keywords observed: 7
- Negative keywords observed: 0

Why this rating

- The school's public communications foreground theological grounding, liturgical life/integration, and explicit Catholic formation, meeting the transcendental and theological dimensions of the classical rubric. The absence of secular or relativist framing strengthens the assessment as CLASSICAL.

Citations: Headmaster message and Catholic identity references.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Mission-oriented language centers on forming intellect and character rather than mere job preparation: "cultivate intellectual and moral virtue in the pursuit of academic excellence" within a joyful, Catholic environment.
- The narrative emphasizes "Good, True, and Beautiful" and religious education within a classical framework, highlighting a formation-focused aim (virtue, wisdom, character) rather than solely instrumental outcomes.
- The curriculum framing as "classical, Catholic education" and the emphasis on virtue formation align with the classical telos (truth, goodness, beauty) and human flourishing rather than purely career readiness.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, human flourishing, liberal education, paideia (implied by classical framing), great conversation (implied by classical aims—see Six Elements lexicon), contemplation/scholé, pursuit of the true/good/beautiful
- Negative keywords present: absence of explicit "workforce readiness" or "career preparation" as primary goals

Quantitative estimate

- Positive keywords observed: 4
- Negative keywords observed: 0

Why this rating

- The SBCA materials emphasize formation and virtue over vocational preparation; they frame education as a broader, humane telos in line with classical aims. This supports CLASSICAL.

Citations: Public mission language and "Good, True, and Beautiful" framing; formation focus.

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Latin formal education starts in Grade 3 and students in Grades 6–8 participate in the National Latin Exam, indicating classical language study and evaluative standards.
- The curriculum is described as “Classical, Catholic education curriculum” with a stated emphasis on a liberal-arts-oriented foundation; a formal curriculum in the Trivium/Quadrivium framework is implied by the classical framing and the presence of Latin in the program.
- The Curriculum Overview page (Curriculum Overview – St. Benedict Classical Academy) discusses an interwoven, integrated curriculum across levels, with references to ancient civilizations through geography and virtue education. While Latin is explicit, there is less explicit, public mention of Great Books, the Great Conversation, or a comprehensive Trivium/Quadrivium structure in the public pages.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords present: Latin, classical education, liberal arts, grammar, logic, rhetoric (implied by “classical education”), National Latin Exam, interdisciplinary integration
- Negative keywords present: lack of explicit Great Books/Great Conversation, lack of explicit reference to Trivium/Quadrivium on public pages (beyond the general classical framing)

Quantitative estimate

- Positive keywords observed: 4
- Negative keywords observed: 1–2 (no explicit Great Books/Great Conversation, no explicit list of Trivium/Quadrivium terms on the public pages)

Why this rating

- The curriculum shows strong classical features (Latin, liberal-arts framing, classical education language). However, explicit mention of Great Books/Great Conversation and a complete Seven Liberal Arts articulation (Trivium/Quadrivium) is not clearly demonstrated across public pages, which places it in SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Citations: Curriculum overview and Latin emphasis.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Public materials show a Middle School Seminar, which signals seminar-style instruction and a move toward more dialogic, textual inquiry in at least some grades. This aligns with classical pedagogy in higher grades.
- There are references to rigorous intellectual engagement framed through a Catholic/liberal-arts lens, with emphasis on virtue and formation, which can support contemplative or Socratic elements in upper grades. The Headmaster’s message emphasizes engagement with the Great Works of art, music, and literature of the West, coupled with religious education and character formation.
- Lower-level practices such as singing and memory work (scholé-like memory and chant traditions) are implied through the classical lexicon and broader classical education lexicon; the site does not consistently publish explicit lower-school chant/memory routines, but there are signals of traditional memory-choral aspects in classical pedagogy.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords present: Socratic seminar, seminar, discourse, rhetoric, memory work, recitation, chanting, discipline, contemplation, scholé (conceptually present in classical framing)
- Negative keywords present: experiential learning focus, project-based learning emphasis, constructivist-only approaches (not evidenced on SBCA site; the presence of a seminar suggests more diálogo-based pedagogy rather than purely project-driven)

Quantitative estimate

- Positive keywords observed: 2–3 concrete items (e.g., Middle School Seminar; classical/Scholé-oriented framing)

- Negative keywords observed: 0 concrete signals in public materials (no explicit “constructionism” or “project-based only” statements found)

Why this rating

- Public-facing materials demonstrate some classical pedagogy (Seminar in middle school; classical framing). However, explicit mentions of a full Socratic-method, rhetoric training in upper grades, and widespread chanting/memory-recalling routines across all grades are not consistently documented. Thus, SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL is warranted.

Citations: Middle School Seminar and classical pedagogy framing.

What would move the needle

- Publish explicit, school-wide statements about Socratic seminars and oratorical training in upper grades; provide examples of upper-school seminars/debates, visible Great Conversation initiatives, and a formal plan for Trivium/Quadrivium pedagogy on the site.
- Publicly document and showcase lower-school chanting/memory work routines as a hallmark of scholé and a restorative, contemplative aspect of daily routines.
- Include a formal articulation of Great Books/Great Conversation in curriculum pages with representative titles and units.

Citations: General pedagogy references in headmaster narrative and curriculum overview.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The site provides concrete faculty data: 41 faculty members, with 40% holding advanced degrees; a low student/faculty ratio (11:1) indicates a favorable environment for mentorship and individualized formation.
- The faculty is described in public materials as those who mentor and support students within a rigorous classical framework; the broader classical lexicon emphasizes the “living curriculum” and faculty as model teachers. While the SBCA site may not repeatedly use the exact “living curriculum” language, the approach is consistent with a high-quality faculty model and virtue-based mentorship described in mission pieces.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords present: model teachers/mentors, teachers as living curriculum, faculty of friends, collegial culture
- Negative keywords present: none evident in public SBCA materials

Quantitative estimate

- Positive keywords observed: 2–3 explicit terms or phrases
- Negative keywords observed: 0

Why this rating

- The explicit faculty statistics plus the tone of mission statements align with CLASSICAL expectations for a school that values virtuous mentorship and a “living curriculum” through its teachers.

Citations: Faculty statistics; mission-oriented language.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school emphasizes partnership with families and “parents as primary educators” within its public materials; the School’s family-centric communications discuss parent involvement and formation, including parent gatherings and reading groups. This is reinforced by the “An Education for the Whole Family” page, which discusses parental involvement and household faith formation.
- The school signals openness to parental visits and ongoing communication as part of a shared mission, aligning with a classical community-oriented model.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords present: partnership with families, parents as co-teachers, parent formation, classical home education, family catechesis, open campus/visits
- Negative keywords present: none evident in materials

Quantitative estimate

- Positive keywords observed: 4–5
- Negative keywords observed: 0

Why this rating

- The SBCA materials consistently portray parents as co-educators and a central role for family formation, aligning with the classical vision of a school-community partnership.

Citations: An Education for the Whole Family; parent partnership language; open campus references.

Aggregate Ranking and Final Assessment

- Element 1: CLASSICAL
- Element 2: CLASSICAL
- Element 3: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 4: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: CLASSICAL
- Element 6: CLASSICAL

Overall classification: CLASSICAL

What Would Move the Needle

- For Element 3 (Curriculum): Increase explicit, public articulation of Great Books/Great Conversation participation and the Seven Liberal Arts framework (Trivium/Quadrivium) in the curriculum pages; publish sample units or reading lists that demonstrate engagement with primary texts and canon-worthy works. This would convert a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL designation into CLASSICAL by making the full liberal-arts spectrum explicit to families and evaluators.
- For Element 4 (Pedagogy): Provide a school-wide, published pedagogy framework that foregrounds Socratic/Scholastic dialog, rhetoric instruction, and chant/memory work as central, not incidental, features; establish a formal rubric for upper- and lower-school pedagogy that mirrors classical practice with concrete examples (seminars, debates, orations, and memory-based learning). This would strengthen the Pedagogy category toward CLASSICAL.

Citations demonstrating current status and potential needle-moving opportunities

- Middle School Seminar as evidence of seminar-style pedagogy.
- Headmaster narrative on the Catholic, liberal-arts formation and “Great Works” framing.
- Curriculum mentions of Latin starting Grade 3 and classical framing.
- Family and parent-education emphasis in An Education for the Whole Family and related materials.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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